

ANNUAL REPORT



the action northeast trust
2022-23



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YEAR AT A GLANCE

the ant turns 22!



the ant turned 22!

On 13th October, 2022 the ant celebrated its 23rd Foundation Day with much pomp and enthusiasm. The celebration was graced by a few government officials and community members from advisory committee of the ant.



Biodiversity Walks

For the first time, the ant organised biodiversity walks in various project locations with staff members and members from local communities with the aim to emphasise on the importance of local plants as a reservoir of nutritional and medicinal benefits. Started on the eve of the World Environment Day, knowledgeable members from the communities guided the participants during the walk and helped in preparing herbariums.



Summer Camps

the ant organised summer camps for children in various locations of Chirang in the month of July. Children participated in various activities such as talent shows, drawing sessions, performing action songs, games, etc., to give a space to children from these remote villages to socialize and learn through fun-filled activities building their confidence and communication skills.



the ant participated in five months RTL Training

the ant staff members practised leadership skills and tools to design transformational projects in the five months Radical Transformational Leadership programme designed by Monica Sharma. 48 staff members embarked on this journey from August till December.



the ant welcomes New Executive Director

Bringing his 22 years of experience in the development sector, Netaji Basumatary, ex-Regional Head of the Indo-Global Social Service Society (IGSSS) and a native of Rowmari, the home of the ant, assumed the position of Executive Director of the ant with effect from 1st January, 2023.





the ant features in Visual Storyboards and the Wire

Centre for New Economic Studies (CNES) covered a few projects of the ant. With the team of student researchers and photojournalist Jignesh Mistry, explored the ant project sites through audio-visual documentations to understand the changes it is bringing in the socio-economic conditions of the communities living in Bodoland. Articles on project LEAP, CTR and Aagor Weaves also featured in the Wire.

ANALYSIS

EDUCATION

Reflections From a Project Tackling Learning Challenges in Assam's Bodoland Region

The Learning Ecosystem Augmentation Project aims to improve quality education in lower primary and middle schools in the region. How has it fared?



the ant at BIKF

IDEA (Institute of Development Action) got the wonderful opportunity to curate the theme "Gender Empowerment" at the first Bodoland International Knowledge Festival, 2023.





From insightful discussions on understanding gender, marginalised gender and sexual identities, gender-based discriminations and violence to exhibition of books, posters and resources on Gender, Gender Based Violence & Discrimination, Sexual Health and Hygiene, the two days programme received active response and engagements from young curious minds seeking to further understand and explore issues on gender. Students, faculty and academicians from various institutes across Bodoland attended the sessions.



Women for the Change!

It is with utmost delight that we want to share the felicitation of our four women change makers – Haseena Khatun, Damyanti Brahma, Laxmi Chetri, Phungbili Basumatary and Mina Tudu by the Social Welfare Department under the Ministry of Women and Child Development for their exceptional roles in changing gender roles in the society.

Sexual Harrassment Workshop

the ant strives to create a safe and inclusive space for its staff members. A half-day workshop was organised in December at the Don Bosco Institute, Kharguli, Guwahati, and conducted by Anurita P. Hazarika, State Coordinator, North East Network, and external member of the ant's Internal Committee.





Children and Youth Development

Shiksha

Shiksha saw an increased ownership by the guardians and community members in learning about the quality of education provided by these centres. Out of 42 meetings with the Village Education Development Committee (VEDC), 38 of the meetings were called by the VEDC members. The VEDC also conducted 194 meetings out of 216 parents' meetings held in the year.

Learning from Exposure

For students from the remote areas of Chirang and Bhutan, even one primary level government school is far from their sights in their villages. Exposure to various institutions and their work can ignite the motivation of these students through introducing them to various skills and opportunities that they can aim for. The students from Middle Elementary Study Centres (MESC) visited the Regional Science Centre and Srimanta Sankardev Kalakshetra in Guwahati where they learned about scientific phenomena and got an exposure to the culture and traditions of various communities in Assam. Children from the CDCs learned about college systems, hazard management and railway systems during their visits to colleges, Fire & Emergency Services and Railway Stations.



ASER Test

The Annual Status of Education Report (ASER) test was conducted in 26 learning centres in Kuklung and five learning centres in Udalguri to assess the reading, writing and maths solving level of the students enrolled in the primary and middle school level. The students of Kuklung centres showed commendable results in the tests. The report shows that 72% of the lower primary children can write from dictation. In the middle school level 83% can read a story and 92% can write from dictation while 72% students can do divisions comfortably.



Experiencing for Learning: Nutrition for Education

Improving the health and nutrition of students is an important component of learning. Without proper intake of nutrients, the brain's capacity to absorb new information reduces. Learning then can become exhausting for the students. Most of the students in the learning centres also come from deprived families. With the involvement of the students enrolled in the learning centres and their parents, Shiksha constructed a demo nutrition garden at the Nama Garo Basti L.P. School in Udalguri. The students and parents received training on vermicompost making, land preparation and plantation techniques from the livelihood team of Kuklung. They planted seeds of local vegetables from their villages in raised beds made by the students. During the process, the students also learned to apply their knowledge on geometric shapes and measurements, and learnt about nutrition.





Building Blocks of Community Ownership

Ghututola is a very poor village near the Indo-Bhutan border area situated about 14 km. north of the Udalguri town and inhabited by Santhal community. Most of the families in the village support themselves with small farming and daily wage labour. The quality of education that their children was receiving was very poor. Most of them completed only the basic level of education and started working as daily wage workers. Financial restraints also makes it impossible for the guardians to afford private tuition. When the AICT made interventions through establishing a Child Development Centre (CDC) in these poor areas, the children of Ghututola were also enrolled. The centre was started with the help of the village elders, parents and community organisation in building the shelter for the classes. However, after building basic structure, the parents and guardians neither gave much heed to the additional needs of the centre in making the centres comfortable for the students to attend the classes nor did they enquired about the performance of the teacher and the classes in general. But, as they observed that the teacher took classes regularly in the centre, parents and guardians started taking notice of the quality of education being provided in the centre and took up the responsibility to aid in infrastructural development by mending and repairing the centre from time to time.



Winds of Change

Amtaz Khatun is an inspiration to many young girls in her village Dongsia para, near the Manas National Park, where girls get married at a young age. Currently pursuing her Bachelors of Arts in Bijni College, her only option of formal early education was an L.P. school in her village that didn't function well. Due to her family's poor economic condition, she couldn't afford for private tuitions or schools. As a result, Amtaz enrolled in Shiksha's remedial learning centre where she improved in learning concepts of English, Science and Maths both at the primary and middle elementary levels. The result of her progress secured her 1st Division with letter marks in matriculation and 1st Division in Higher Secondary as well.

Ransai has been interested in studies since he was a kid, but due to lack of proper school in his village No. 4B Sonapur, he was on the verge of dropout in 2015. His parents like any other families in Kuklung, Chirang, engaged in daily wage labour and occasional selling of vegetables that didn't give enough to support their child's education in private schools or tuitions. The only school in the village also closed down in 2021 due to irregular classes because of its non-provincialised status. Ransai was enrolled in Shiksha's remedial centre in 2015 where he got support to grasp the concepts of English, Science and Maths from primary till middle elementary level. Ransai's interest in studies was restored. Overcoming the many other issues of his village where nightly visits by the elephants raised hue and cry in the village disturbing their sleeps, Ransai passed with 1st Division in matriculation in 2022.





Learning Ecosystem Augmentation Programme (LEAP)

The main aim of project LEAP is to improve the quality of education in government primary and middle schools, and to make quality education accessible to children in remote forest villages on the Indo-Bhutan border of Chirang district of Assam. Through intervention in government schools with teachers' training on ASLA implementation, establish criterias for child-friendly schools, and running learning centres in forest villages, LEAP achieved some of the goals of the project. Child-friendly schools are important to provide a holistic and safe learning environment for children. As the 141 government schools for intervention were not child friendly, the project aimed for transforming 50% of these schools into child-friendly schools. The schools were assessed based on a number of criterias such as separate toilets for girls and boys, clean toilets, availability of drinking water and electricity, well-lit classrooms, safe playgrounds, open library, etc.

LEAP provided ASLA (Assamese Second Language Acquisition) materials to 17 Lower Primary Assamese schools and trained the teachers to make learning easier for non-Assamese students and prevent their drop-outs. In the far flung villages in forest areas bordering Bhutan, children have no access to government schools. LEAP aimed to reach out to 400 children through 14 Forest Learning Centres (FLC), 2 Model Learning Centres (MLC) and 9 Remedial Learning Centres (RLC).

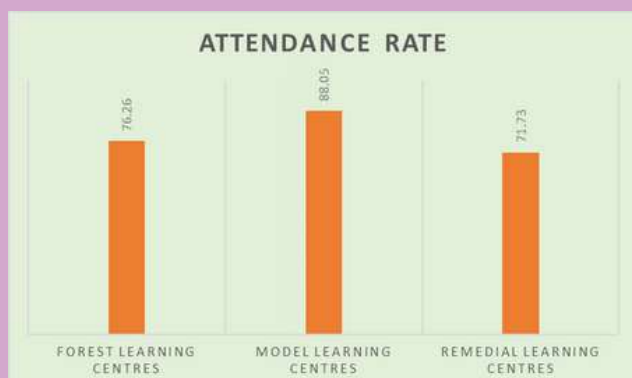




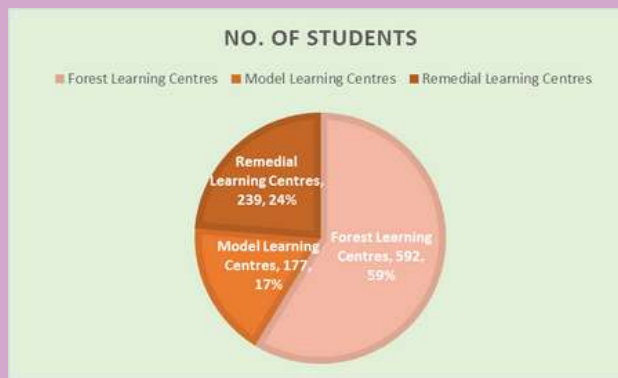
Targets Achieved

- 76.78% (108) of the schools achieved a child-friendly environment
- The attendance rate of non-Assamese native speakers was 80.18%
- In 2022, more than a thousand children were enrolled across the centres with an average attendance rate of 74.64%. A little more than half of the children enrolled in class 3-5 can now perform multiplication or division.

ATTENDANCE RATE



NO. OF STUDENTS



Support from District Administration:

Situated in a forest area, the forest learning centres are provincialised by the government. But the education department provided other support for better experience for the children in accessing quality education. Two learning centres namely Koraibari Model Learning Centre (MLC) and North Simlaguri Forest Learning Centre (FLC) received books and since 2022, Koraibari MLC has been receiving Mid-Day Meal.



Regional and District Level Science Mela

In order to cultivate scientific temperament among young children, LEAP conducted school level science melas and a district level science mela giving a platform to the children to apply their scientific knowledge. Groups were selected in the school level science mela to present at the district level science mela that was held in the month of November. 39 projects were presented at the district level in the presence of DEEO, BEEOs, DPOs of SSA, Chirang and other invited guests.



Mid-Term Evaluation of the LEAP

Two external evaluators carried out a mid-term assessment from 6th February to 11th February on the overall achievement of the Learning Augmentation Ecosystem Project (LEAP) in fulfilling its major objectives, and to document important learnings. On the basis of the assessment, the evaluators provided future directions to the project. The evaluators were Malini Mukherjee, an educator and manager of international quality education initiatives, and Debasish Sarkar, MIE, Chairman of Deeksha Education Trust.



Amidst the Child Friendly Schools of Mangalore and Udupi



The LEAP team had a very enriching and exciting exposure visit to Mangalore and Udupi from 20th to 22nd February. The team visited govt. lower primary and high schools, panchayat office and School Monitoring Committee and Coordination Forum, where they explored child friendly classroom systems, and community and Panchayat involvements in school management.



Colouring the Rainbow (CTR)

Since 2019 many youth and children as well as parents have become part of Colouring the Rainbow (CTR) witnessing the journey of self-improvement of the individuals involved in the project. CTR engages with children and youth through S4D (Sports 4 Development), Manoranjan, Rainbow sessions and sessions with persons with disabilities. Parents have seen significant changes in their children's behaviour and attitude towards education, health, etc. and this positive response from the parents and children have motivated the team to continue the CTR project. With another fresh start from the month of July 2022, the year for CTR has been an eventful one with young Ultimate Disk players gearing up with training and tournaments. Visiting coaches and guests interacted with the children and youth spreading the spirit of Ultimate game!

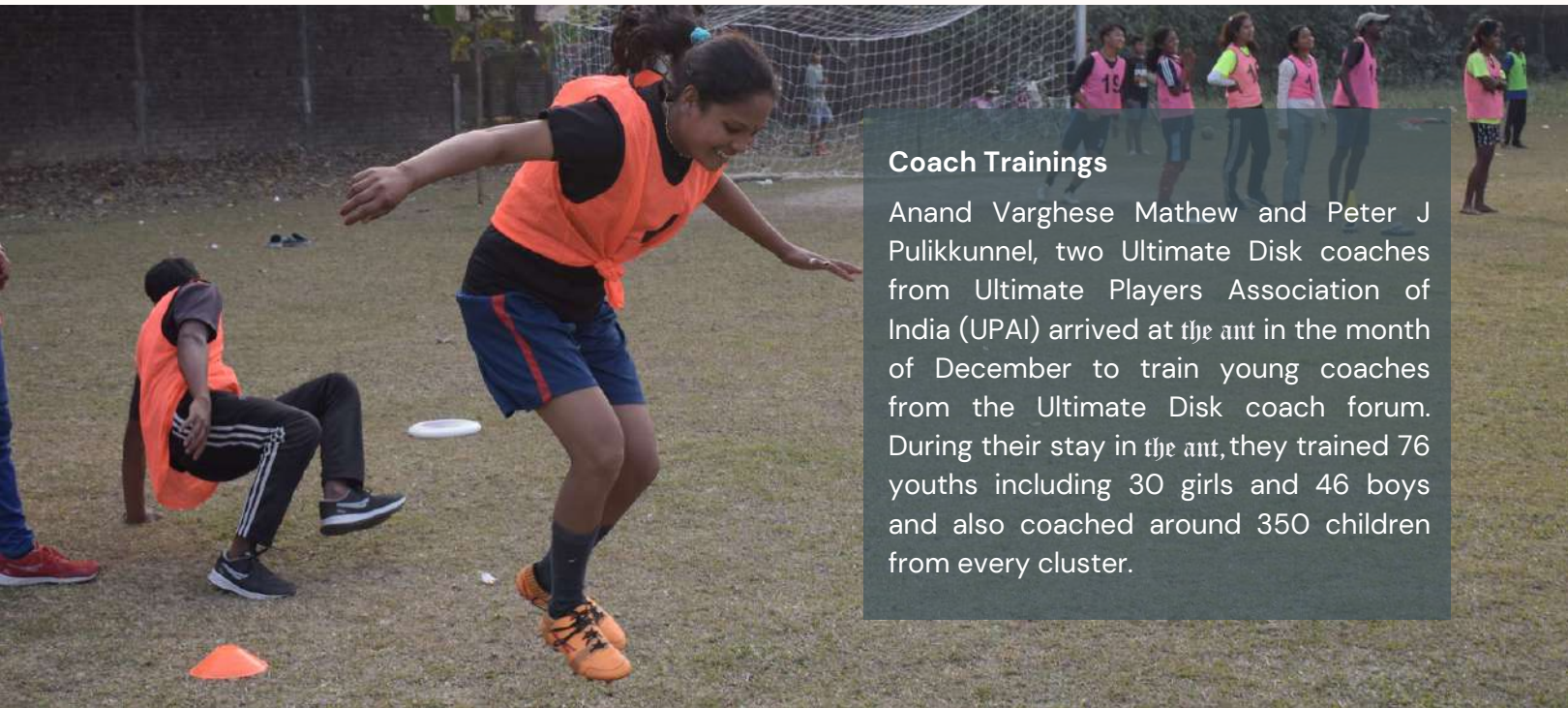




Cluster Level Tournament

In the month of November, a cluster level tournament of Ultimate Disk was held where 20 teams comprising 448 players, 197 girls and 251 boys, participated. Children and youth from five districts namely Basugaon, Deosiri, Amguri, Patabari and Kuklung in Chirang district participated in the tournament and out of the 20 teams, seven teams were selected for the Central-level tournament.





Coach Trainings

Anand Varghese Mathew and Peter J Pulikkunnel, two Ultimate Disk coaches from Ultimate Players Association of India (UPAI) arrived at the aint in the month of December to train young coaches from the Ultimate Disk coach forum. During their stay in the aint, they trained 76 youths including 30 girls and 46 boys and also coached around 350 children from every cluster.

In the cold winters of mid-January, 2023, Michael Brenner, a gold medalist at the Ultimate Disk World Championships arrived at the aint all the way from the United States to train 35 young coaches (19 girls and 16 boys) of the Ultimate Coach Forum. The training was conducted across Basugaon, Deosiri, Kuklung and Rowmari clusters till 26th March, 2023.





Ultimate Disk Coaches' Training and National Championship Series 2022-23

24 young Ultimate Disk players took part in the National Championship Series 2022-23 Mixed Nationals organised by Ultimate Players Association of India (UPAI) in Surat, Gujarat from 24th February to 26th February, 2023. The team trained by guest coach Michael Brenner secured the second position in Spirit Award which is given to the teams played with ethical sportsmanship.



Career Guidance

In the light of very few youth and children reaching universities or establishing strong careers due to lack of information, CTR organised a career guidance session for the students appearing for High School Leaving Certificate (HSLC) and senior secondary certificate exams. Dr. Dwimalu Basumatary, Assistant Professor from Zamduar College, Kokrajhar facilitated the session introducing the various career options and the qualifications and preparations needed for each career path.





Creating Inclusive Space for Individuals with Disabilities

Striving to leave no one behind, CTR is aiming to build a space devoid of gender discriminations, communal and ethnic violence, and discriminations against persons with disabilities. Through building relationships between PwDs and the communities, including CwD in sports sessions, and awareness sessions on their entitlements and government schemes, CTR is making space inclusive for the individuals with disabilities. Five CwD parents' groups were formed in five clusters to connect them with the District PwD Association through half-yearly meetings. The first half-yearly meeting was held in January, 2023. CTR facilitated PwDs with access to disability cards, hearing aids, wheelchairs, PwD pensions, etc.

On the International Disability Day, CTR collaborated with All BTR Disabled Association in organising an event at Bhawraguri Binyakhata H.S. School, Kokrajhar. 59 persons with disability and their parents attended the event where the awareness initiatives of the CTR project was highlighted. Janwara Begum was offered a memento, television and wheelchair for academic excellence by the ant.





Friends Across Barriers (F.a.B)

The multi-ethnic and multi-religious region of Bengtoli cluster in the Chirang district of Bodoland Territorial Region (BTR) in Assam had gone through a period of conflict in the past giving birth to an atmosphere of strife and mistrust among the communities living there. In such a conflict ridden society, the rights of women and children are endangered, and a holistic development of the youth is jeopardized.

Project F.a.B was launched in 2021 as a collaborative programme between the ant and three other organisations in Manipur to strengthen the rights of women and children through peaceful conflict resolution, conflict transformation and peace building. The project engaged in various activities with children, youth and community stakeholders to build a peaceful, safe and sustainable environment. At the community level, the project engaged in various workshops and awareness programmes with parents and community institutions to promote peaceful ways of conflict resolution. With parents, F.a.B conducted workshops on parenting skills to strengthen parent-child relations, and workshops on anger management and mental health to prevent the exposure of children to anger at home for their socio-emotional development.



Additionally, F.a.B engaged with community institutions such as SHGs in a series of five workshops on Gender Equality where 137 women and 88 men participated. At the end of the workshops, the participants realised that most of the community institutions were headed and dominated by men. The impact of the workshop was reflected during forming the committees for organising the Ramdhenu/Jaikhlong mela which were all headed by women. Community stakeholders such as Gaonburah, VCDC members, VLCPC members, SHG members, student unions, etc. met with the government officials such as DCPO, DLSA secretary, etc. for the second time to discuss about the project activities and to reach at an understanding of working together on issues pertaining to children and youth.



To create a safe learning environment and make quality education accessible to children, F.a.B worked towards building leadership in children through children's clubs, hand holding the government schools and strengthening school management committees (SMCs).



With 813 children enrolled in 25 clubs across 48 villages, 51% of the children are girls! The club children carried out different roles and responsibilities enhancing their leadership qualities. Their leadership shone in organising various public events that highlighted the importance of their rights such as World Conservation Day and International Child Day. With the help of field facilitators, they organised an event called Knowing Each Other's Festivals with the objective of making children aware of the festivals celebrated by different communities in their area and thus, aiming at breaking the cultural barriers between the children. F.a.B provided TLMs on maths in 21 schools and provided handholding support to 19 schools through training. 50% teachers could implement joyful learning practices in their classrooms. To ensure a joyful learning environment, mobile libraries were organised in the schools which includes sessions like reading aloud of the books to the children. With the introduction of mobile libraries, the interest for reading increased among the children. The project held regular meetings with 20 SMCs informing them about the composition and responsibilities of SMCs. This led them to monitor the school activities ensuring a clean environment and quality mid-day meals in the schools.





Empowering Youth and Building a Sustainable Future

The unmatched energy and enthusiasm of the youth of Bengtol to bring positive change in their society made it possible to carry out many of F.a.B's objectives. 358 youths from the age of 15-25 years out of which 53% were girls were engaged in the programme through 17 youth clubs formed across 17 revenue villages in Bengtol. From organising International Youth Day for the first time in Bengtol to organising awareness sessions and campaigns, the youth achieved a lot within a year.



In collaboration with student unions and the VCDC, F.a.B established a Youth Information Centre and library space for the youth to co-create development programmes and exchange ideas. 30 youths also participated in a two-day training programme and co-created a standard operating procedure for democratic functioning of the centre.

The youth organised two large scale awareness events such as the International Youth Day and the Global Action Month campaign raising awareness on the environmental rights of children and youth through street plays, cleanliness drives, biodiversity exhibitions, etc. Following a training on Gender Equality and Issues, the youth facilitated a Gender Awareness programme in July with SHG members on the topic of sex and gender. The youth also collaborated with the community elders in organising a biodiversity walk and documenting the local plants which were later exhibited in public spaces of Bengtol. The ant conducted career counselling sessions and a vocational training workshop. Six youths have already started planning on their mushroom cultivation design.

In order to identify livelihood opportunities for the vulnerable families, Family Based Livelihood Plan (FBLP) assessment tools were made covering 500 families depending on their livelihood patterns and assets of the families. These tools were made to better identify the different scopes in income generating activities. Based on the FBLPs, members of the SHGs were provided with skill development orientation and training and nine families received a revolving fund of 10,000 rupees.

In the Spotlight

Mina Tudu, a shining star from Bengtol, represented our community at a national-level convention on peace building in New Delhi. Numerous others embraced leadership and climate advocacy through workshops organized by the Assam Youth Network.

Sports became an important medium of breaking gender barriers between youth of different genders and promoting gender equality. 90 youths were enrolled in football (30) and Ultimate Disk (60) sessions. 34 girls were also enrolled in mix-gender and mix-ethnic groups. Two mix-gender teams for Ultimate Disk were formed during the year. During this period, our youth engaged in Ultimate Disk played in two cluster level tournaments and one regional tournament. Ultimate players Sonali Ray, Shakirul Ali, Essau Basumatary, Mohorsing Basumatary, Sonalika Brahma, Tika Maya Newar and Pobon Basumatary are already taking responsibilities to train new members, checking drop outs and assist the staff to enquire the reasons.

Ramdhenu/Jaikhlong Cultural Mela

Like a ramdhenu (rainbow) that appears after the showers of a gloomy day, hundreds of people from different communities gathered at the Jangkrikhang field on a warm November demonstrating the rainbow-like social fabric of Bengtol. The Ramdhenu/Jaikhlong Cultural Mela was a peacebuilding initiative by the communities to expose each other, especially the younger generations to the different cultures of the communities in Bengtol. From food stalls to live demonstrations of making traditional crafts, the Ramdhenu/Jaikhlong mela created a vibrant atmosphere for two days leaving a deep impression on the memories of the communities living in Bengtol.





Youth Leader to Community Leader



Meet Moinuddin Ali, a 20-year-old from Bengtol who has a mission to make education accessible to all. Despite facing financial challenges himself, Moinuddin organized an awareness campaign on drug abuse and designed a project to reduce the rate of school dropouts. He started taking tuitions for underprivileged children in his neighbourhood and even created a YouTube channel "Syed Gyan Assam" to make his classes accessible to all. Moinuddin also promotes gender equality through sports, with 34 girls enrolled in mix-gender and mix-ethnic groups. Additionally, he organized the Ramdhenu/Jaikhleng Cultural Mela, a peacebuilding initiative to expose different cultures to the younger generations in Bengtol. From a youth leader to a community leader, Moinuddin is making a positive impact on his community.



Empowering Women and Girls

AVAHAN (Against Violence at Home – Act Now!)

As the world was returning to apparent normalcy after a year of panic, pandemic and lockdowns, AVAHAN (Against Violence at Home – Act Now!) worked actively to reach out to as many people and groups as possible to spread the message of action against gender based violence. Along their journey of activism, they strongly emphasized on establishing linkage with the state institutions through dialogues and participation in collaborative efforts. From strengthening community-based organizations with intervention skills to launching strong campaigns against gender-based violence, AVAHAN had a very eventful year in 2022.

AVAHAN's activities and achievements for the year includes:

Women in village organizations received training on sexual health, reproductive rights, gender, domestic violence laws, and child sexual abuse at both basic and advanced levels.

Reached 34 adolescents in residential workshops, and 27 showed increased awareness of violence against women and girls in post-training tests.

29 families leading happy lives and no violence since last one year.

Prompt action and response of key leaders at village level in supporting the survivors and solving the case.



Strengthening Response Groups

Response Group, a vital institution of the AVAHAN to establish community ownership and agency in tackling domestic violence, is formed with members of the local communities. These groups provide immediate support to domestic violence survivors with counseling and connect them with district authorities to handle their cases. Apart from their immediate response, they engage in awareness activities in the villages to address the issue of domestic violence in their society. With the aim of motivating and encouraging the response groups in their work, the ant started a felicitation programme to recognise the best performing response group every year. All the 94 functioning response groups across Chirang district attended the programme where Brahma Para-Nepali Bosti response group was felicitated with a cash-prize of 10,000 rupees for their unwavering courage and active engagement with the communities.



ঢালিগাঁৱত দ্য এণ্টৰ উদ্যোগত কৰ্মশালা

গণ বার্তা, কাজলগাঁও, ১৮ জুনঃ 'সম্প্রতি মহিলা সকল গৃহ হিংসার বলি হোৱা ঘটনাসমূহ এক সামাজিক ব্যাধিত পৰিণত হৈছে। নিজৰ ঘৰতে স্বামী আৰু স্বামীৰ পৰিয়ালৰ লোকৰ দ্বাৰা নিৰ্যাতিত হৈ মনে মনে সহি থাকিবলগীয়া হৈছে একাংশ মহিলা। তাৰ মাজতো চিৰাং জিলাত গৃহ হিংসাৰ বলি হোৱা বছৰি দুই শতাধিক মহিলাই ধৈৰ্যৰ বান্ধ জিঙি মুকলিকৈ ওলাই অহা দেখা গৈছে। আজিকালি ডমেণ্টিক ডায়ালগ কোবোনা ভাইবান্ধৰ দৰেই যেন ঘৰে ঘৰে সোমাই গৈছে।' - দ্য এণ্ট নামৰ বেচৰকাৰী সংস্থাৰ উদ্যোগত চিৰাং জিলাৰ ঢালিগাঁও হাইস্কুলত আয়োজিত এখন কৰ্মশালাত সংস্থাটোৰ প্ৰতিষ্ঠাপক জেনিফাৰ লিয়াঙে এইদৰে কয়। এণ্টৰ সহকাৰী প্ৰকল্প সমন্বয়ক ছান্তাৰ আলী আহমেদৰ সঞ্চালনাত অনুষ্ঠিত সভাখনত প্ৰগ্ৰেম সমন্বয়ক লক্ষ্মী ছেত্ৰীয়ে কয় যে বিগত ৫ বছৰত জিলাখনত ৮১৪ গৰাকী মহিলাই গৃহ হিংসাৰ বলি হোৱা ঘটনা পোহৰলৈ আহিছে। ২০২০ বৰ্ষৰ জুলাইৰ পৰা ২০২২ বৰ্ষৰ মে' মাহলৈ মুঠ ৪২৩ গৰাকী মহিলাই উক্ত ঘটনাৰ বলি হৈ সংস্থাটোৰ কাষ চাপিছে আৰু ইয়াৰে ৬০ শতাংশই ১৯-৩০ বছৰীয়া বয়সৰ ভিতৰত।

Exposure for Response Group Members

20 members of response groups from 20 villages in Chirang, Assam visited three villages in Uttar Pradesh for an exposure trip to learn from the experiences of communities and people from other parts of the country in intervening and working towards eradicating domestic violence in their regions. With the guidance from organisations like Asian Bridge India, Gramya Sansthan and Gramin Punar Nirman Sansthan, the group interacted with different communities, especially men and boys who have been taking steps to break gender-role stereotypes starting from their own households.





Walkathon for Peace and Unity!

‘Peace in the home to peace in the world’– “UNITE! To end violence against women and girls.” With this clarion call, the 11 days walkathon commenced 25th November, 2022 in solidarity with the global “16 Days Campaign Against Gender-Based Violence”, the 11 days walkathon was one of the major highlights of the year that garnered huge support from the local communities and captured the attention of the local media.

With over 1,000 participants walking through many villages, the walkathon collaborated with VDCs and community organizations. During the 11-day journey, the walkers engaged with various communities and leaders, advocating against gender-based violence and promoting safety for women and children. The event concluded with a public meeting featuring Shri Pramod Boro, Chief Executive Member of the Bodoland Territorial Council, rallying the public to unite against violence and promising government support centers for domestic violence issues.





One Billion Rising Campaign

Dancing on the beats to break the silence around gender-based violence, AVAHAN spearheaded the 2023 campaign across Chirang and Bongaigaon on 14th February with a group of youth and the ant staff members spreading the message of One Billion Rising Movement – Rise for Freedom! Through flash mobs and street play in schools and public spaces, the campaign brought the attention of the people towards the message – violence against women and girls exists in every corner of the world and we must all break our silence on it. On the day to celebrate love, the group of campaigners spread the words of creating a world free of violence, and full of love and compassion towards each other.



BTC (Bring the Change)

Parents and communities engage in dialogues with the project team through community and parent meetings to discuss girls' rights, issues like pursuing higher education, child marriage, and gender norms. They aim to promote positive changes in household gender norms. In 24 villages, 41 community meetings and 24 parent meetings were held to discuss project goals, objectives, and activities, fostering mutual commitment and support. Over time, more parents began attending these meetings, spurred by the positive impact, including one community member who became active in sessions after the BTC team, with the assistance of Child Protection Officer, ChildLine, and Child Welfare Committee, rescued her minor daughter from an early marriage. Witnessing her daughter's educational progress after BTC counseling boosted the mother's confidence in the project's goals and objectives.



Parents and communities are involved in dialogues with the project team members through community and parents meetings to provide a space to discuss about the rights of the girls, issues that the girls are facing in their development such as pursuing higher education, child marriage and disempowering gender norms, and to encourage positive changes in gender norms at the household level. 41 community meetings and 24 parents meetings were held in 24 villages to discuss the project's goal, objectives and activities for mutual commitment and support. With time and development of the project, parents started showing interest and their support by attending these meetings. One of the community members actively started participating in these sessions after the BTC team with the help of Child Protection Officer, ChildLine and Child Welfare Committee rescued her minor daughter who eloped and married a man. The changes she saw in her daughter about her education after receiving counselling from BTC gained the confidence of the mother in the project goals and objectives.

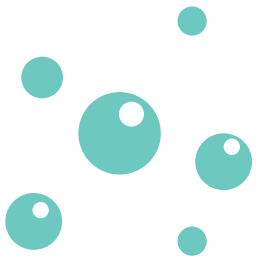


Exchange Learning and Networking

The girls participated in peer learning activities through exchange learning programmes. During the programme, girls visited villages of their fellow project peers where they not only engaged in extra-curricular activities and craft making, but they were also exposed to the cultures of other communities. Older girls who are part of the alumni forum also took sessions with the girls on Ultimate Disk, menstrual health, etc. during weekly sessions.

The project staff and the girls engaged in networking with the district level health, education, ASLRM and District Child Protection Unit. The project staff worked closely with district child protection officer, child line and child welfare committee to resolve two child marriage cases in the community. With the aim to inspire and motivate the girls to choose their own career paths, they were given the opportunity to meet professionals during their exposure visits to district court and hospital.





From Cloth Strips to Pads: Breaking the silence around periods



At the age of 17, Chandrika was still shy to talk about period issues with her family and friends openly. Chandrika was already a budding Ultimate Disk athlete. Her eyes sparkle whenever she talks about her love for sports. But for generations, women and girls in Chandrika's village feel restricted physically especially during menstruation due to use of cloth to control period blood. Due to this, many girls including Chandrika miss their classes and obstructs her sports practice. Sanitary pad was still a far and expensive concept for many families in the village. The BTC staff members introduced the use of pads to the girls enrolled in the weekly sessions. As she continued with the sessions, she gradually learnt about menstrual health and hygiene and she understood the importance of educating others on it. Now she feels confident to talk about period issues with male relatives and classmates. "Earlier I used to only inform my mother about my period cramps and ask for medicine, but now if I need pads and medicines for period pain, I can directly ask my father and elder brother." These sessions on menstrual health and hygiene also developed confidence in the girls to speak up on things that matter to them. Chandrika is one among them. She is now very confident about herself and about her peers spreading awareness on menstruation in public. "I have seen young girls from my village are slowly gaining confidence. All the girls who attend the sessions have become like a peer group, supporting each other while facing period issues and motivate each other to take part in different extra-curricular activities." As the girls become more aware, the community of parents and the whole village learns about the issues the girls go through during menstruation.



Livelihood Programmes

Livelihood Kuklung

The Livelihood Kuklung programme's plate was full this year with providing the farmers with the know-hows of organic farming such as making their own vermicompost, biopesticides, etc. 283 farmers received training from the unit out of which 90% are women farmers. The team worked in collaboration with government institutes such as Krishi Vikas Kendra (KVK) to optimally utilise the fund allocated for the project activities. With the support from KVK, 200 farmers were provided seeds and training to prepare kitchen gardens, out of which 198 farmers are actively maintaining their gardens.

Out of the 13 training sessions on vermicompost, 3 were conducted by KVK with 75 farmers, and the rest were conducted by the unit staff with 100 farmers. Kuklung has a huge problem of elephants entering the villages in search of food that discourages the farmers from growing paddy and vegetables. To tackle this issue resulting from declining forest covers, the farmers were trained to prepare lemon saplings for fencing their kitchen gardens. The farmers were able to produce 11,050 saplings of Assam lemon trees.



The focus of the project is not only to improve farmers' income from agriculture but improving the nutrition of the communities especially children. The ant collaborated with schools and parents to start school nutrition gardens (SNG). While the ant gave technical support and seeds, the funds for allocating land and fencing came from the schools' Youth and Eco Clubs. Additionally local seeds were contributed by the parents. The parents also maintained the gardens and collected cow dung that were used for composting. The ant organised a biodiversity walk with the livelihood staff and farmers to highlight the nutritional value of food locally sourced.





Farmers meetings were held quarterly by village organisers to create a space for the farmers to discuss and exchange knowledge regarding farming issues such as pest control, types of plants to grow and when to grow them. Apart from knowledge exchange, farmers also plan on collecting money for purchasing seeds, selecting locations for nurseries, preparing manure, etc.

In addition to farmers' meetings, the ant staff participated in "Farmers' Mela" organised annually by Krishi Vikas Kendra (KVK) to gain knowledge on the agricultural machinery and techniques that the staff later shared with the farmers. The farmers were also given first-hand exposure to agricultural information through exposure visits to KVK centres at Kamrup and Gossaigaon.



The ant also equipped the farmers with knowledge and information on integrated pest management. Two training sessions were conducted with the help of resource persons from Bongaigaon District Agriculture Office where farmers were demonstrated on making biopesticides using traditional pest control techniques. In addition to supporting the farmers in agricultural activities, the ant also organised value addition training such as pickle making, and awareness raising on prevention and treatment of diseases of cattles.



“

“The distribution of seeds and saplings by the project team has supported us in agriculture by increasing our production. It has not led to a drastic change in our farming process, but it surely adds to the produce we get from the seeds from the market.”, said Rotmali, a 60 year old women farmer from Dharampur, Kuklung. Before taking up agriculture full-time nine years ago, Rotmali was selling vegetables occasionally as an addition to the income earned from wage labour. When they started farming for selling, initially they used the hybrid seeds from the market, but the income was so meager that it was not enough to buy more seeds. They would borrow money and share part of the produce to the lenders leaving them with little money to buy seeds for the next batch. With support from the livelihood project of the ant at Kuklung, Rotmali and her family received free seeds and sapling through the joint seed collection and saplings cultivation system in which the farmers engaged with the project contribute small amount to buy seeds which are then stored along with the saplings in a farmer’s house for further distribution. Rotmali also participated in the vermicomposting training organised by the ant and now can make her own manure using just organic wastes and earthworms, saving her the cost of buying manure and chemical fertilizers.

”



Making Opportunities for Uplifting of Lives in Deosiri (MOULD)

Making Opportunities for Upliftment of Lives in Deosiri (MOULD) completed a year on 31st October, 2022. Being a fairly new project, the first half of the year of project MOULD was spent mostly on identifying the target population, mobilising the communities, forming self-help groups and joint liability groups and introducing the project objectives and planned activities to these groups, and developing a few modules for training and awareness. The project covers three thematic areas to reach the goal of the project: Livelihood, Health and Rights/Entitlements.

During the period, 2000 households were identified as vulnerable families based on criterias set by the MOULD team including the criterias decided upon in consultation and discussion with leaders and members of SHGs/Federations and community.

the ant reactivated a few old SHGs groups. Along with the new SHGs created by the ant, training on objectives of SHGs, conceptual clarity, bookkeeping and financial literacy was provided. 19 SHGs that didn't have any material for bookkeeping have also been provided with books for documenting the proceedings. The village organisers and facilitators monitor and acknowledge their progress followed by feedback/suggestions for improvement. *"Because of your mentoring support in promoting SHGs, our group has revived through proper book-keeping, regular savings."* (Lucia Hasda, Secretary of Jahrayu Sarna SHG)



Five cluster level federations were formed with the aim to sustain skills of the SHG members through peer learning where one federation equals to 100 SHGs equally distributed across five VOs (village organizations). The federations will also work towards networking and building linkages with various government departments to bring in resources and facilitate the provision of documents for the communities to avail their rights and entitlements. The federations collaborated with the AINT in organising two public events in the Deosiri cluster – International Youth Day by creating a space at a community hall for the youth, parents and community members to reflect and hold discussions on issues that impact their lives and communities and the International Day of Rural Women through a community level workshop and gathering to discuss the importance of recognising rural women's contribution to the rural workforce and supporting women in various livelihood ventures. Photo exhibition and craft exhibition on women's work in Deosiri were part of the event to show the paid and unpaid labour of women.

In order to identify livelihood opportunities for the vulnerable families, Family Based Livelihood Plan (FBLP) assessment tools were made covering 500 families depending on their livelihood patterns and assets of the families. These tools were made to better identify the different scopes in income generating activities. Based on the FBLPs, members of the SHGs were provided with skill development orientation and training and nine families received a revolving fund of 10,000 rupees.





During interactions with the communities, many families are found to have members with chronic diseases such as tuberculosis and heart disease incurring heavy medical expenses. Accordingly, two manuals were developed for the staff and provided training covering topics on the Rights of Children, Germs and Illnesses, Hygiene and Health, Nutrition and Health by the *the ant*. In addition to that, a one-day workshop on Health & Nutrition was conducted by Dr. Swati Singlai for *the ant* staff.

At the community level, *the ant* conducted awareness sessions with 64 SHGs on health issues mainly non-communicable diseases, malaria, tuberculosis, etc. *the ant* conducted multiple tests through Mobile Medical Unit camps in multiple villages conducted multiple tests through Mobile Medical Unit camps in multiple villages, after receiving several reports of children falling ill in the month of July. A seminar on “Women and Child Health” was organised in October with 130 participants including children in the presence of district health officials and community health institutions. The discussions were focused on the impact of various health issues such as malaria, TB and mental health on maternal and child health. To ensure proper nutrition of the communities especially the children, MOULD trained 32 School Management Committees (SMC) on nutrition garden for the mid-day meals.



Community Media Unit (CMU)

the ant community media unit (CMU) was started in late 2021 with the aim to produce audio-visual materials on local socio-economic issues, community initiatives, and traditional community knowledge for educational purposes. The goal of the project is to use media to bridge the gap between communities and generations through knowledge sharing. From dubbing educational videos to producing short videos capturing traditional knowledge and skills for solutions, the community media unit started taking shape. The community media unit engaged in vision planning in a four-day workshop facilitated by Pinky Brahma Choudhury, co-founder of Media Unit, Samaj Pragati Sahayog (SPS). The CMU also invited members of other ant projects to workshop and a storytelling workshop to establish an understanding and alignment of interests between the CMU and the other projects of the ant .

● REC





Within a year, the unit released one short documentary titled "Biyad: Love with Nature ". The film follows the journey of Ancharam Narzary, an avid self-taught conservationist working towards saving the diverse orchid population of Bengtol and the nearby region at the foothills of Bhutan. The CMU also shot short videos on traditional knowledge for educational purposes such as "Sandri Hebnaï" (Bamboo Weaving) on the traditional bamboo weaving skills and techniques of the Bodo community, and "How to make biopesticides at home?", made in collaboration with the Livelihood Kuklung project documenting the process of making biopesticides using locally available medicinal plants.

Apart from producing videos, the CMU also carried out the task of dubbing two videos both in Assamese and Bodo for training purposes. The CMU recorded and produced an anthem song for the fellows enrolled in Bring the Change programme.

CONSENT

IT'S SIMPLE AS TEA

জুদি নোঁখোছা দাৰো গনায়থি লানায়নি বেলায়াব জেনায়াব গোলেদোঁ,



In the early days of February of 2023, the CMU facilitated an exposure trip to Samaj Pragati Sahayog (SPS) in Madhya Pradesh to understand the working process of the SPS media unit and the programmes of SPS in strengthening self-help groups and farmers, managing watershed, and other activities of the organization.

Mental Illness Treatment Alliance (MITA)

The low-cost MITA model is designed to provide 10 rupees a day treatment to mental illness patients in remote areas of Assam with the help of partner organizations. The goal of the project is to enable the patients to live dignified, economically and socially productive lives again, ease the pressure off the caregivers, and build community awareness and resilience. 10 partner organizations carried out mental health camps and awareness sessions. Two new organisations partnered with MITA in 2022, but one of the organisations had to discontinue due to low turnout of patients even after six months of partnership.

Patients suffering from Severe Mental Disorders (SMD), Common Mental Disorders (CMD) and Epilepsy received treatment. Data shows that there is an unprecedented growth in the number of CMD cases from 37% in 2021 to 42% in 2022. The total number of registrations increased to 13,232 in December including 3,372 newly registered patients. (Figure in percentage) 30,430 patients received consultations by camp psychiatrists and 28,282 patients showed up for follow-up consultations.





Key Highlights and details:

01

Awareness Camps



- Conducted: 523
- Districts Covered: 12

02

World Mental Health Day (10th Oct 2022)



Location: Amguri Primary Health Centre, Chirang District

- Activities: - Community Interaction
- Emphasis on Physical Health
 - Strengthening Relationships

03

Collaborations



- With Other Projects and Departments
- Focus on Mental Health Awareness

04

Parenting and Mental Health Sessions



- Conducted with F.a.B
- Topics: Parenting Skills, Anger Management
- Target Audience: Parents and Community

05

Staff Well-being Session



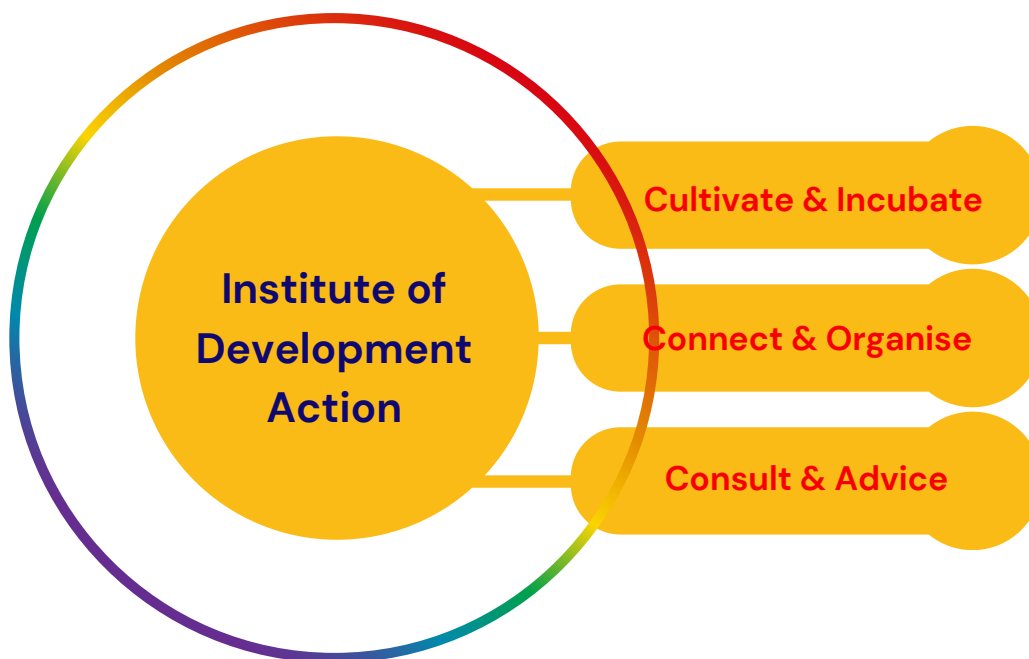
- Collaborated with HR Department
- Promoting Employee Well-being

Besides regular activities, MITA focused on outreaching activities including attending conferences and workshops. MITA participated at the 7th National Conference on World Association for Psychosocial Rehabilitation Indian Chapter. A team of four presented a paper titled "The Equity-Informed Recovery Paradigm in Structurally Vulnerable Clinical Population: A Case Study on Mental Illness Treatment Alliance in Assam". In collaboration with documentary filmmaker Minnie Vaid, the ant produced a short documentary on MITA capturing the essence of the ant's relationship with the patients in their journey to live a life free from fear, and to live a life of dignity. In the 27:09 mins long documentary titled "MITA Cares", four individuals consensually narrated their own journeys in dealing with their mental illness with support from MITA.

Institute of Development Action

the ant's capacity building wing IDeA (Institute of Development Action), located in Guwahati, has been carrying out work in three strategic themes for the past 16 years.

With the unwavering support of Caring Friends, Child Aid Network (Germany), TDH (Germany), BMZ (Germany), and several other local and international organizations, IDeA has developed a unique relationship with local and regional non-profit organizations through trainings, incubations and technical support for carrying out different projects striving towards positive impacts on the lives of communities in Northeast India. Following the three strategic themes, IDeA engaged in the following projects:





Cultivate & Incubate

During this year, with the help of Caring Friends, IDeA supported 15 partner organisations across Assam, Meghalaya and Nagaland. With the incubation of four new organisations, IDeA partner organisations were active in their areas of work.

Here are some key highlights:

- Number of organisations supported – **10** in Assam, **3** in Meghalaya and **2** in Nagaland.
- Area covered – **82** villages across 13 districts.
- Individuals reached – **3529**.



Key Highlights

5

partner organisations from Assam and Nagaland underwent the organisation development workshop facilitated by IDeA during which the organisations realigned their Vision, Mission, Values, and Strategic action plan for the next 3 years.

2513

children and youth continued to learn languages, sports, enhance their critical thinking abilities, and engage in joyful learning activities through the programs of nine partner organisations.

239

persons (men, women, and children) with disabilities were reached out by the two partner organizations by ways of therapy, linkages for aids and appliances, and availing disability and other related documents and certificates.

468

farmers received inputs from four partner organisations through training and services for enhancing income from remunerative farming practices.



Connect & Organise

Launched in 2021 with the aim to create a child-friendly ecosystem in Lower Assam, project ENRICH (Enabling Rights of the Child) is a result of the collaboration between IDeA and five organisations in five districts of Lower Assam. The project helped in creating child-friendly villages in five districts with support from Child Aid Network (Germany) for promoting and securing child rights. IDeA and the partner organisations carried out the project goals through children clubs, organising Shishu Mela with the help of community stakeholders such as schools, SHGs, VHSNCs, ANM, etc. to ensure active community engagement in promoting child rights, organised training, workshop and exposure visit for the partner staffs to enhance their skills and knowledge on the rights of children and youth.

3500 (approx.) children reached out through 88 children's clubs across 47 villages. Conducted regular sessions on child rights related issues such as health, hygiene, socio-emotional learning, education including sports for joyful learning, etc.

One community mobilisation training for partner staffs to enhance their skills in involving communities in promoting and protecting child rights.

One exposure visit for the partner staffs to PATANG, an organisation on youth empowerment and child rights in Odisha, to broaden their knowledge on working with adolescents and youth.

One library workshop conducted for partner staffs to enhance their skills to carry out reading and library sessions in the project areas.



Consult and Advise

IDeA has been the technical support for four local organisations (one in Assam and three in Manipur) that has been implementing project F.a.B (Friends Across Barriers) in 58 villages across five districts since 2021. Supported by terre des hommes (TDH), Germany, IDeA has designed, developed and executed various training modules for children and youth. The year started with a training on child club formation in project villages for 20 project staff members from four organisations. The trainees formed 60 child clubs across 48 villages in Assam and Manipur. To ensure proper functioning of these clubs, the same trainees participated in a training programme organised in collaboration with Kshetra equipping them with skills to conduct sessions on conscious citizenry with the children. Bookworm Trust, Goa and IDeA conducted a training on library initiatives aimed at training the participants on initiating open libraries in schools and communities. Post training 46 libraries were opened by the partner organisations in primary schools and communities. IDeA also directly worked with the youth through five youth centres established in 2022 in collaboration with the partner organisations in project areas. In addition to that, the collaborative efforts between IDeA and Save the Children resulted in the development of a youth resilience manual. To implement the manual, a training was also organised for the trainers.



We couldn't have done it without your support. Thank you to all our **DONORS**

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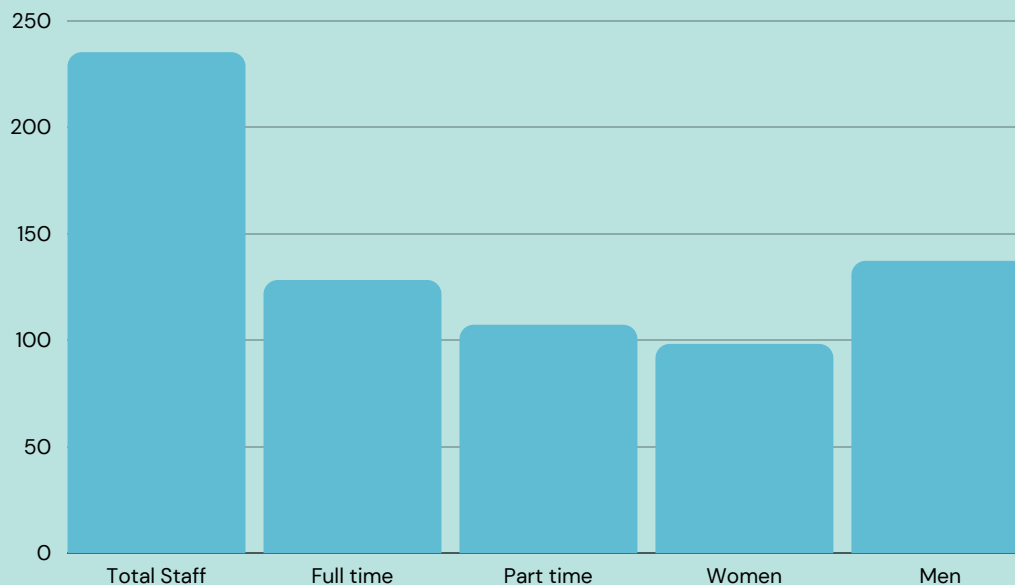
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